



PRESIDENT PRATIBHA PATIL AND PRIME MINISTER
MANMOHAN SINGH WITH THE CABINET

party recently like Beni Prasad Varma and P.L. Punia have been overlooked in favour of loyalists such as the Doon School duo Jitin Prasada and first-timer R.P.N. Singh. The coming assembly polls have also been factored in, but randomly. Since the Maharashtra elections are due in October, it has been allocated seven ministerial berths. Unfortunately, the same logic does not apply to Haryana which has only one minister (Cabinet) and which goes to the polls next January.

Still, there is a glimpse of an assertive prime minister. It is a cleaner Cabinet than the one he had in 2004. He has also managed to get rid of deadwood like Arjun Singh, H.R. Bhardwaj and Sis Ram Ola. Experience still counts. The average age of the Cabinet

is 66. In 2004 it was 67. There are nine former chief ministers on board, including some who lost their states—S.M. Krishna, Virbhadra Singh and Farooq Abdullah (who lost to his son Omar in a way). As Manmohan learnt when his choice of a bureaucrat for finance minister was turned down in favour of the politically adept Pranab Mukherjee, the making of a ministry is a fine balancing act.

The war room warriors, Jairam Ramesh, Salman Khurshid, Anand Sharma and Prithviraj Chavan have been rewarded. There are as many as 29 first timers, including former chief ministers like Farooq Abdullah, Vilasrao Deshmukh, Krishna and Virbhadra Singh. And while performers like Sachin Pilot have been

included, the youth brigade in the ministry consists of pedigreed politicians rather than grassroots ones.

Although the Prime Minister has announced an agenda for the first 100 days, he has wasted 11 precious days in choosing his ministers. The entire exercise has taken some sheen out of the victory. And in the end, it's not a lean, we-mean-business ministry either. With support of 322 MPs, the second innings of Manmohan's Government does have a much stronger mandate to carry out his agenda. The Congress has always claimed that it is the natural party of governance. Now the Prime Minister has to show that his team is up to the challenge. The voter has delivered. It is now Manmohan's turn. ■